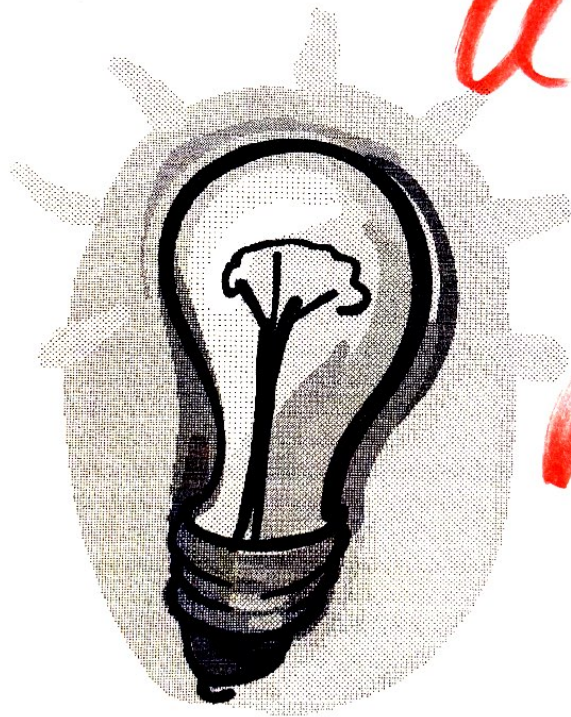


HISTORY II
(H-253)

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TERM PAPER:
The Enlightenment and 18th Century Europe –
Pro's and Con's



a good
paper!

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THE ENLIGHTENMENT 18TH CENTURY EUROPE

In the 1700's a revolution began to sweep through the western European world, but it was not characterized by fighting between armies of men. Instead this revolution was fought a mightier weapon – intellect. A new way of thinking was being introduced – later coined the “Enlightenment,” and the former practice of believing all that was already written and taught was in danger of becoming obsolete. Some consider a man named Galileo Galilei to be the forerunner of this movement but several men were involved with its contagiousness and the spread of the Enlightenment like wildfire. Such men include Johannes Kepler, Sir Isaac Newton, Nicolaus Copernicus, Machiavelli, John Locke, Immanuel Kant, Voltaire, Thomas Paine, and even Thomas Jefferson. This essay will discuss these men as well as others and their role in changing the direction of thought in the eighteenth century. Both pro's and con's will be discussed at length, citing several sources of information that are written specifically and extensively on just this topic. In my short period of study on the Enlightenment, I have found an overwhelming amount of information, which can sometimes make a summary seem like an injustice. However, by focusing on a few main points and spending enough time to elaborate on them thoroughly, this work will be no injustice at all.

The first and speculatively the most positive result of the enlightenment was the birth of three central concepts, which include: the scientific method, rationality and critical thinking, and the social progress spurred by a new desire of the people to strive for good.¹ The scientific method has helped scientists across the world develop theories and find proof for scientific facts. This process, which was a direct result of the enlightenment, has led to earth shattering discoveries and is still doing so to this day. The second central concept of critical thinking has also helped in enormous ways. For a long period of time people would simply accept what they were told and not consider the veracity of the information on their own. Rationality drives a society's progress to the next level far more speedily than simple mindedness; of this there is no doubt. Finally the desire for the good of mankind also came from the enlightenment and in some cases resulted in an upgrade in the class of society. The Enlightenment made people see that a good tomorrow was possible but started with them in every-day decisions. People began to respect life more and, for a brief period, live in harmony.

An expansion on those three central concepts would be another good result of the enlightenment, which was providing a new way of thinking and breaking from the traditional way of learning. This allowed more freedom and creativity, not only in literature and education, but also in government as well as art. The works that were a result of the enlightenment will be discussed later when specific persons of the enlightenment are mentioned. The scientific revolution was the springboard for the enlightenment, and it was the beginning of people using their creative minds to pose question and seek out the answers. Evidentially the traditional teaching that came from the church did not seem to answer all the questions. It should be noted that these teachings, though based on the Holy Bible, were the church's interpretations of what they thought the Bible was saying. This will be a subject that comes up later. Whether the traditional teachings were right or wrong is inconsequential at this point, what matters is the fact that the enlightenment brought fourth the creative minds and reasoning which would show promise for progress in the coming years. The introduction of a book on the age of enlightenment explains this positive aspect of the Enlightenment as follows:

Looking back over the whole development of ideas, one may summarize the intellectual enterprise, which we call the Enlightenment as the commitment on the part of a group of writers to a dual task – liberation and reconstruction... It was necessary to free men's minds for untrammelled speculative and scientific enquiry; and to accomplish this, certain social changes were requisite. The grip of authority, especially of institutionalized theology, had to be loosened.²

A man by the name of John Locke posed ideas that were very influential in changing the way government was run. Lock's influence even extended to Thomas Jefferson as well as the Bill of Rights and the Declaration of Independence. Lock was totally pro-democracy and for ending tyranny and monarchies. "The preamble to the Declaration, excerpted below, articulated clearly Locke's philosophy of natural rights."³

We hold these Truths to be self-evident, that all Men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the Pursuit of Happiness – That to secure these Rights, Governments are instituted among Men, deriving their just Powers from the Consent of the Governed...

Locke also believed human beings were born without sin and were effected by their environment. This belief, though controversial, motivated people to take more care with the raising of their children and their concern for society was responsible for helping it improve. Locke's ideas had quite an effect on the French during that period of time. The call for democracy and an end to tyranny erupted in Revolution in that country. The Revolution, though long and bloody, eventually helped France become a democracy and a better society. Some may

question how much the Enlightenment affected this revolution; however, "The influence of the Enlightenment cannot be disregarded in any history of the French Revolution. But the revolutionaries did not set their course by it's light in the beginning, nor did they steer the ship of state into the haven of the Enlightenment in the end."⁴

Most of the people during the late 1600's were looking for something secure to stand on and on which to base their beliefs. These people were not content to put their faith in the church and what it said they should believe in. They wanted something tangible that they could explain and understand. The enlightenment provided this foundation, and many people latched on to it forgetting about the church's teachings. The new way was a commitment to reason, but not just anyone, instead it was reason based on a scholar. As Immanuel Kant said: "The public use of man's reason must be free at all times, and this alone can bring enlightenment among men... I mean by the public use of one's reason, the use which a scholar makes of it before the entire reading public..."⁵ Specifying who's reason must be free at all times was a very good thing to do, because great chaos could result if everyone brought forth their own ideas and reasoning without at least a scholarly foundation.

Many books were written during the enlightenment that posed good arguments. One such book was written by Thomas Pane entitled "The Age of Reason". Other great works were also written such as the Encyclopedia, who's principal editor was Denis Dierot. "The Encyclopedia was a monument to the Enlightenment. Its numerous articles on science and technology and its limited coverage of theological questions attest to the new interests of eighteenth-century intellectuals."⁶

The positive aspects of the Enlightenment are very weighty and without them this country and this world would indeed be very different to this day. Whether it would be better or worse cannot be determined, the fact that things would not be the same cannot be questioned. In the next section the unfavorable results of the enlightenment will be discussed to give the reader a full understanding of the results the enlightenment produced in 18th Century Europe.

It can be found in most writings beginning with the scientific revolution up to the 19th century that the shift from accepting the churches theological reasoning to the free reasoning of scholars has brought down the credibility of the Holy Bible. One must wonder why the focus seems to be on disproving the Bible, when the fallacy incurred was the direct result of the Catholic Churches interpretation of the Scriptures. No where in the Good Book does it say that "the earth is the center of the universe," yet this belief was held to be true and taught and preached by the church.

Another great flaw in the enlightenment was the teaching that "nothing was to be accepted by faith."⁷ The attack on faith was actually an attack on the church because faith is the foundation for belief especially in religion. Many scholars did not want to accept that some things simply couldn't be proven by science. For example: the beginning of the universe cannot be proven. No one was there when it all started, and the only written record of the beginning is in the Bible, which the scholars have rejected leaving them source-less. Other theories do not prove anything; on the contrary, they suggest a creative means by which something could be reasoned out apart from hard evidence. The word 'hard evidence' is used, because some scientists have found evidence that supports other evidence, but it is not conclusive. One example of this is the dating of the earth by fossils, and the dating of the fossils by the layers of the earth they are found in.

The bottom line of all this discussion is that some things have to be accepted by faith. And faith is not a religious word. Non-religious people negatively deem faith a religious word because it is used so freely in the church; however, everyone has faith, it is just a question of where their faith lies. Some people put their faith in believing that there is no God, some have faith that there is a God, but whether they think God exists or not, they have faith which can't be denied. The Enlightenment negatively affected the spirituality of many people because they did not accept spiritual things that were believed by faith and then understood later. On the contrary these people tried to reason things out, and then, when finding an explanation that suited them because they understood it, they put their faith in that explanation.

Another problem in the Enlightenment was the failure to find a common ground between the scientists and the theologians. Neither side wished to compromise and consider the facts presented by the other. Both the scientists and the theologians had great insights and proposed tremendous arguments to prove their belief. Neither side can be blamed for this unfortunate result, but both caused the matter. If the theologians would have went back to their scriptures and studied more carefully they would have found that their interpretations might have been false. This of course takes a great deal of humility, admitting ones mistakes always requires humility, but evidently these scholars of the Bible thought doing so would produce more harm than good. In the end, however, the harm was done regardless.

The goal of keeping the Bible up on a pedestal as the infallible word of God was not achieved because the scientists began to show proof that their theories were correct. The scientists could have also looked to the Bible and some of them did. Galileo Galilei himself said, "A hundred passages of the holy Scripture teach us that the glory and greatness of Almighty God are marvelously displayed in all His works and divinely read in the open book of the heaven."⁸

Other scientists knew that their discoveries were not simply due to reason, and that scholarly thinking could not prove that the majesty of this world was a result of chance. Sir Isaac Newton said "This most beautiful system of sun, planets, and comets could only proceed from the counsel and dominion of an intelligent and powerful Being... this Being governs all things, not as the soul of the world, but as Lord of all. Johannes Kepler also is quoted saying, "We may behold how God, like a master-builder, has laid the foundation of the world according to order and law. "I give thee thanks, Lord and Creator, that Thou hast given me joy through Thy creation."⁹

What is so amazing is that over the years people have started and continue to praise the discovery of these men and talk about how great they are¹⁰, when Newton and Kepler themselves knew where the praise and glory were due, and it was not to their discovery and certainly not to themselves. One such distortion over time appears in the textbook issued by the Merchant Marine Academy in history class. This book states, "Galileo held that on questions regarding nature, one should trust to observation, experimentation, and mathematical reasoning and should not rely on Scripture."¹¹ How can a textbook assert such an idea given what Galileo has been quoted saying about the holy Scripture? Now, some may interpret Galileo's quote differently and imply that he was only saying that God's works could be seen in nature. However, Galileo was saying that the Scriptures teach, not only that nature (His works) show the glory and greatness of Almighty God, but also specific details about them (His works).

Over the years certain discoveries have been made and they are included here to show what Galileo was talking about when he mentioned what "a hundred passages of the holy Scripture teach us." Previously stated ~~in this paragraph~~ was the fact that if the theologians would have ^{gone} ~~went~~ back to their scriptures and studied more carefully, they would have found that their interpretations ^{were actually} ~~might have been~~ false. The following statements must be considered carefully with an open mind; there are ~~two~~ ^{three} categories and ~~seven~~ ^{eight} verses from the Bible. These statements are consistent with certain fields of science, and interpreted correctly, they do not contradict but affirm what scientists have discovered.

● Statements Consistent With Astronomy

MIDN Adam Johns, 1/c
Section 1M2

- The Bible frequently refers to the great number of stars in the heavens. Here are two examples.

Genesis 22:17

Blessing I will bless you, and multiplying I will multiply your descendants as the stars of the heaven and as the sand which *is* on the seashore; and your descendants shall possess the gate of their enemies.

Jeremiah 33:22

"As the host of heaven cannot be numbered, nor the sand of the sea measured, so will I multiply the descendants of David My servant and the Levites who minister to Me."

Even today, scientists admit that they do not know how many stars there are. Only about 3,000 can be seen with the naked eye. We have seen *estimates* of 10^{21} stars—which is a lot of stars. (The number of grains of sand on the earth's seashores is estimated to be 10^{25} . As scientists discover more stars, wouldn't it be interesting to discover that these two numbers match?)

- The Bible also says that each star is unique.

1 Corinthians 15:41

There is one glory of the sun, another glory of the moon, and another glory of the stars; for one star differs from another star in glory.

All stars look alike to the naked eye. Even when seen through a telescope, they seem to be just points of light. However, analysis of their light spectra reveals that each is unique and different from all others.

- The Bible describes the precision of movement in the universe.

Jeremiah 31:35,36

Thus says the LORD, Who gives the sun for a light by day,
The ordinances of the moon and the stars for a light by night,
Who disturbs the sea, And its waves roar. (The LORD of hosts *is* His name):
"If those ordinances depart from before Me, says the LORD,
Then the seed of Israel shall also cease from being a nation before Me forever."

- The Bible describes the suspension of the Earth in space.

Job 26:7

He stretches out the north over empty space,
He hangs the earth on nothing.

● **Statements Consistent With Meteorology**

- The Bible describes the circulation of the atmosphere.

Ecclesiastes 1:6

The wind goes toward the south, And turns around to the north;
The wind whirls about continually, And comes again on its circuit.

- The Bible includes some principles of fluid dynamics.

Job 28:25

To establish a weight for the wind,
And apportion the waters by measure.

The fact that air has *weight* was proven scientifically only about 300 years ago. The relative weights of air and water are needed for the efficient functioning of the world's hydrologic cycle, which in turn sustains life on the earth.¹²

The following statements from the Bible must be taken for what they are worth, and one must question why the theologians did not find these during the time of the scientific revolution. Perhaps if they were read and someone pointed them out to the theologians something might have changed. However, considering the response of the Church to these new ideas, some involved accusing the scientist of heresy and burning them, there is very little hope that even this evidence could have changed their mind.

Two more statements on geology must be made at this point because they directly refer to Galileo and the Catholic church, which is in bold:

● **Statements Consistent With Geology**

- The Bible describes the Earth's crust (along with a comment on astronomy).

Jeremiah 31:37

Thus says the LORD: "If heaven above can be measured,
And the foundations of the earth searched out beneath,
I will also cast off all the seed of Israel
For all that they have done, says the LORD."

Although some scientists claim that they have now measured the size of the universe, it is interesting to note that every human attempt to drill through the earth's crust to the plastic mantle beneath has, thus far, ended in failure.

- The Bible described the shape of the earth centuries before people thought that the earth was spherical.

Isaiah 40:22

It is He who sits above the circle of the earth,
And its inhabitants are like grasshoppers,
Who stretches out the heavens like a curtain,
And spreads them out like a tent to dwell in.

The word translated "circle" here is the Hebrew word *chuwg*, which is also translated "circuit," or "compass" (depending on the context). That is, it indicates something spherical, rounded, or arched—not something that is flat or square.

The book of Isaiah was written sometime between 740 and 680 BC. This is at least 300 years before Aristotle suggested that the earth might be a sphere in this book *On the Heavens*.

This brings up an important historical note related to this topic. Many people are aware of the conflict between Galileo and the Roman Catholic Pope, Paul V. After publishing *A Dialogue on the Two Principal Systems of the World*, Galileo was summoned to Rome, where he was forced to renounce his findings. (At that time, "theologians" of the Roman Catholic Church maintained that the Earth was the center of the universe, and to assert otherwise was deemed heretical.)

We could not find any place in the Bible that claims that the Earth is flat, or that it is the center of the universe. History shows that this conflict, which took place at the time of the Inquisition, was part of a power struggle. As a result, scientific and biblical knowledge became casualties—an effect we still feel to this day.¹³

The next attack on the Enlightenment will be on its idea of progress in society. In Bernard de Fontenelle's work *Conversations on the Plurality of Worlds* "Fontenelle's lady rejoices in the knowledge that the human mind is capable of making great progress."¹⁴ The Enlightenment made people believe that "progress, at least intellectual progress, was very possible."¹⁵ This idea expanded to include the possibility of the entire world becoming "better" after the American Revolution when a greater reality of individual liberty and representative government were realized.¹⁶ Of course to any ordinary person this may seem like a great thing in the Enlightenment, and it is – until this ordinary person sees the consequences of such ideas. "The French philosopher Jean Jacques Rousseau argued that the accumulation of knowledge improved human understanding *but corrupted the morals of human beings*."¹⁷ (emphasis added) The Enlightenment thinkers believed all this progress was possible – better societies, better people – by economic and social improvements while the moral decay of society ran its course. The overwhelming and convicting question this raises is which of the two is more important: a person's pocket book, or HIS SOUL??

The final blow that will be dealt to the enlightenment in this paper will be to only a few of the ideas of John Locke. As mentioned previously, John Locke held to the teaching that man was not inherently evil. "Rather, said Locke, the human mind at birth is a blank slate upon which are imprinted sensations derived from contact with the world. These sensations, combined with

the mind's reflections on them, are the source of ideas. In effect, knowledge is derived from experience."¹⁸ This theory has absolutely no grounds when taken in the light of specific situations where a child is raised with all love and care from his parents and then once the child becomes an adolescent he or she turns into a prodigal and goes against everything they were taught as they grew up. Certainly the environment a person lives in directly affects their behavior; this is obvious. However, to claim that everyone is perfect to begin with and ignore the fact that mankind has a sinful nature, (a natural tendency to do evil) is nothing short of naïve. The belief appeals to man, though, because it gives him a sense of control of his life; he becomes the master of his own destiny without any preconceived faults. It is a simple truth that a man's heart is not changed from the outside by his environment, but from the inside by spiritual revelation. It is indeed undeniable that humans are spiritual beings, and that part of a person is what changes them and determines their character. In John Locke's assumption of the non-existence of a sin nature he is failing to notice the spiritual side of humans, and this is a great fault.

Before concluding, the author of this paper would like to deter and pose a question of the Enlightenment. Was this really enlightenment, or was it something else? And, was there a previous enlightenment? The first question poses far more controversy than the second; therefore we will answer the second first. If the golden ages of societies are taken into account, there can be no doubt that they experienced some sort of enlightenment in their prime. Greece experienced it's golden age in Athens in 500 B.C., Mesopotamia had Babylon in 500 B.C. also, Mexico had the Myan centers from 500 B.C. to 500 A.D., Italy's Rome was in it's prime from 200 B.C. – 200 A.D., Egypt experienced the Dynasties of Pharaohs around 1500 B.C. and China experienced their golden age with Dynasties of Emperors long Before Christ. "All the Golden Ages are past! Most of the people living in these places today are experiencing anything but splendor. The heights of cultural achievement are long gone. People wonder, 'How can these things be?' and the problem lies in our limiting ideas about the technical abilities of ancient man. The point is simply this: Ancient man did accomplish many outstanding things because he was indeed able to do so. The means by which he did such things are a mystery because such knowledge was forgotten."¹⁹ This explanation may raise more questions than it answers about an enlightening before The Enlightenment, but it is notable that these ideas in the 18th century were not necessarily new, they were just new to the culture and they had a different effect than they apparently would have in ancient times.

Back to the first question that was posed: Was the Enlightenment really an enlightening? It is the belief of this author that people must answer this question for themselves, and once having done so, hold to their answer but keep an open mind. Many of the negative affects of the Enlightenment as well as the positive aspects have been discussed in this paper. A helpful conclusion can be drawn however that might help the reader with answering the question for himself once and for all. First we must look at human nature and briefly discuss the ten Laws of Need. "First is the law that a need not satisfied tends to store its energy. Second, the stronger a need is, the less particular we are about the way we satisfy it. Third, Indifference results from excessive indulgence. Fourth Social influence may serve to stimulate or inhibit our needs. Fifth, if a strong need remains unsatisfied, other needs tend to be neglected. Sixth, needs that are not satisfied may sometimes be replaced by other needs. Seventh, needs often conflict with each other. Eighth, needs sometimes combine rather than conflict. Ninth law is that no need can be fulfilled in social isolation. Finally the tenth law states that there is a 'threshold' of a need whereby greater than average indulgence tends to increase the amount of activity required to satisfy the need."²⁰ These needs were mentioned to show that every man has them and what happens as a result of the needs. The Enlightenment played an enormous role in awakening these needs and not only that, but also urging people to take action based on their needs. The Enlightenment may not have helped satisfy the right needs of the people. The movement in addition could have detracted from the people's spiritual needs by substituting man's reason for Biblical explanation as discussed. Although this may be true it does not change the fact that apathy is the cause of one of the greatest tragedies of life: people who sit around and do nothing and are unsuccessful physically, mentally or spiritually. Shakespeare speaks about this attitude in Hamlet in the last lines of "To Be or Not to Be:"

Thus conscience does make cowards of us all,
And thus the native hue of resolution
Is sicklied o'er with the pale cast of thought,
And enterprises of great pitch and moment
With this regard their currents turn awry
And lose the name of action.

The greatest result of the Enlightenment was preventing such tragedy. When people sit around and think about what they should do or not do, or what they should and should not think about, action is lost. Triumph of mankind is only found through action. When the needs of a soul are known, and the action to achieve those needs is in place, man can - then and only then - truly become a success.

*This is good -
but be more
specific
about
your
opinions
and reactions.*

Therefore we see the complexity and controversy of this subject and how difficult it is to reconcile the differences and produce a concrete solution. The debate over who was right and who was wrong during the Enlightenment – just as are many issues today – must be reasoned out and decided upon by the individual, just as I mentioned earlier. Most people are content to agree with the majority, but I am not. I have made up my mind, concerning this matter at least, and I would like to close by sharing what I believe to be true. I do believe the Enlightenment brought a new way of thinking; however, this new way of thinking was oppressed by the Catholic Church and many other traditionalists for the wrong reasons. When this happened those who wanted to believe the new ideas had to disagree with the church and thus from all religion because the Catholic Church held kind of a religious monopoly. Therefore they could not press further into the Holy Scriptures because the Church held them and would only read them to the people at mass. Therefore some of the truth was lost in the translation and omission. This was not the case for many who continued to believe and pursue God while believing the theories and scientific advances were good and right.

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The job of interpreting the Scriptures is a difficult one and cannot be done without God's help through the Holy Spirit. It is my belief that the leaders of the Catholic Church attempted to do this and in some instances they turned out being wrong. The most serious of their errors was claiming to be infallible in their interpretation. There was only one man who was infallible and that was Jesus Christ, no one else will ever be and this is something we just have to accept.

After studying the Enlightenment, I felt much enlightened myself, but at the same time I am saddened. I am sad because I look around today and these things that are clear to me are invisible to those who have been blinded from the truth. God is real, the Bible is true, and we are frail and fallible. Galileo believed that, as did many other scientists and scholars of that day. Why so many people reject this today is a mystery to me. Maybe it's pride, or maybe it's just the way they have been taught. Maybe a combination of both which would require a humility to deny teaching and ^{realize} ~~know to accept~~ another truth must be accepted by faith. I suppose we will all know one day who was right and who was wrong. I've done my homework and know beyond a shadow of a doubt what side I'll be on. I hope you've done the same!

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- ¹⁵ Ibid.
- ¹⁶ A History of Western Society. (p. 696)
- ¹⁷ Sources of the Western Tradition, Volume II, From the Renaissance to the Present. (p. 72)
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- ¹⁹ Dennis R. Petersen Unlocking the Mysteries of Creation. Creation Resource Foundation, El Dorado, CA © 1986 (p. 4-29 - 4-30)
- ²⁰ John L. Hill The Enlightened Society. The Theosophical Publishing House, Wheaton, IL © 1987 (p. 189-90)
- very good!!

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of work!*